

COM 101 Communication Skills

Mid-semester examination ; 10 October 2024

Marks - 25; Duration - 1 hour ; 9:30 - 10:30 a.m

- I. Read the article and answer the questions that follow. The answers should be paraphrased in your own words. Please do not copy directly from the sentences in the paragraphs, but try and understand the meaning, and then express in your own words (12 marks):

Food collected directly from nature appeals to me at a fundamental level. Growing up in India, with roots in the western Himalayas, I enjoyed family holidays that involved fishing or looking for wild berries. Even in the drier urban plains where we normally lived, my parents introduced us to roadside fruit like the vitamin- (and worm-) rich hard berries called *ber*, the sweet and tangy *jamun* and *falsa* that dyed our fingertips and tongues purple, and small wild mangoes that line some of Delhi's older avenues. As an adult living and working in the green and cosmopolitan university town of Oxford, I continued my occasional forays into wild foods. I picked blackberries and apples, and made English crumble. I steeped the otherwise inedible sloes in sugar and gin, and treated visiting friends and family to a delightfully scarlet, fruity tippie. Yet only in the past two years have I embraced the gathering of wild food as an almost daily activity. Like many others, I am uncomfortable with ultra-processed food, which is disembedded from soil, climate, culture and place. A handful of corporations control the bulk of agricultural inputs such as seeds and fertilisers, and also the global food trade. Our cheap food, produced in large volumes for high profits, emerges from battery farming, chemical dependence, pollution and the exploitation of labour in globalised value chains. The cheapening of food, and life, in the industrial food complex is symbolic of our distancing from nature. This distancing is at the heart of the climate crisis.

My forager friends and online acquaintances may dabble in foraging as an occasional hobby. Others have made it a more integral part of their lives, gathering wild fruit, grasses, leaves, mushrooms, roadkill, fish and fowl for much of their food consumption. Not all foragers have access to open green spaces. Many forage in their everyday surroundings. These might be hedgerows and urban greens that produce more edible items than most of us can imagine. The tiny patch of ignored garden in front of my house has a profusion of *dandelion* – a ubiquitous, cheerful yellow flower atop long, jagged leaves. The flower gives way to a wispy seed ball that our neighbourhood kids blow into the air for fun. Dandelions grow like weeds but are edible and highly nutritious. Young dandelion leaves, rich in vitamins A, B, C and K, as well as iron, zinc and potassium, have gone into our salads and omelettes this spring and summer. Dandelion flowers, also a source of vitamins and antioxidants, have brightened our pancakes and biscuits, and infused herbal body oil. Committed foragers harvest dandelion roots, which apparently make a coffee equivalent – provided you are willing to clean, dry, roast and powder them for your cuppa. I am not there yet, though I have harvested a range of teas from my garden patch and immediate surroundings. These include red and white clover, camomile, cleavers, lemon balm, and strawberry leaf and rose. The teas taste good. Importantly, they have therapeutic properties that were widely known to our herb-harvesting ancestors but are now lost to most of us. A quick read tells me red clover, for instance, helps with respiratory inflammation, and skin conditions like eczema. Commercial outlets sell dried red clover with promises of alleviating the skin and hair deterioration linked to ageing, as well as the effects of menopause and even some types of cancer. Once I started recognising and looking out for plants like dandelion and clover, I find them everywhere – on the side of the urban path leading up to my workplace, along farm tracks, in public parks. Of course, I have to be certain that the local council hasn't been enthusiastic with weed killer, and doused wild, edible flowers with pesticides. Increasingly, I come across local governments and community groups, including the one in my neighbourhood, showing an inclination for wilding. We know that wildflowers and what we think of as 'weeds' are ecosystems for pollinators like bees and butterflies. They are also possible food sources for us, provided we tap into them in moderation and don't crowd out our fellow beings.

The return of foraging is happening in locations and among communities that can still access the commons. In England, the commons have shrunk to around 3 percent of the land area, from around 50 per cent in preenclosure times. These commons are cherished by foragers, with my foraging friends well aware of their legal right to most wild produce, provided it is for personal consumption. Local women want to prevent the land from being surveyed by officials facilitating the solar project. Some of these people are involved in movements against renewable energy installations that now threaten cherished commons. This includes a vocal, ongoing protest against a Solar Farm, a 1,400-hectare development proposed on extensively farmed land, commons and a fraction of the private estates. Around 80 per cent of the residents of the surrounding 15 villages object to the solar farm, and have successfully pressured a local college to withdraw from the

development. Preservation of the commons, and the way of life these enable for the local community, is central to the opposition's argument.

Foragers in different parts of the world are bringing attention to the land and water on which our food, lives, history and culture depend. The green of the forager's world and the greener world promised by tech-driven climate fixes are currently on different planes. The scepticism of the fisherman facing displacement exemplifies this divergence. Without a conciliation, elite climate solutions will prove to be no solution at all for people like him.

Meanwhile, I continue to forage for joy and sustenance, while increasingly relating to the commonsdependent communities. We talk land and energy, while discussing and enjoying seaweed, fruit, varieties of edible greens, and local brews made with rice, sorghum and plant saps. We criticise the green agendas of governments and rich businesses, disembedded from the land. And we raise a toast to the land that continues to, somehow, still look after us.

- a. What is the core idea of this article?
- b. "This distancing is at the heart of the climate crisis" - What does the author refer to in this context? Do you agree and why?
- c. The author mentions "access the commons". How is foraging associated with the commons?
- d. Why does the author write about the dandelion? What are some of the important qualities of the flower mentioned?
- e. What is the meaning of "wilding"? How is it different from foraging?
- f. What title would give to the article? Justify your choice.

II. Answer the following questions briefly in your own words:

1. What are the important functions of communication? (2)
2. What do you understand by barriers to communication? Why are Individual/Psychological Barriers so significant? (2)
3. What is the difference between Selective Perception and Halo Effect? (2)
4. What are the C's of effective communication? Explain the two C's : Courtesy and Conciseness (1+2)
5. What is the meaning of Annotation? Why is annotation important in effective reading? (1+1)
6. How are Linear notes different from Pattern notes? (2)